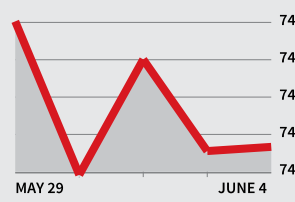


the hindu businessline

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	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23416.55	+10.95
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.12	0
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.78	+0.08
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	155461.00	+1046
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	261088.00	-487

BEHIND SCHEDULE

Monsoon reaches Kerala three days late, with the State getting widespread rain; IMD sees more rain across the State **p10**

LONG-TERM POTENTIAL

India should stop selling itself short, says Citi Chair and CEO Jane Fraser **p7**

QUICKLY.

EXPANDING TIES
India, Venezuela eye partnership beyond oil



New Delhi: Venezuela's acting President Delcy Rodríguez and Prime Minister Narendra Modi held wide-ranging talks on Thursday focused on forging a stronger energy partnership and expanding ties beyond oil to sectors such as critical minerals, mining, agriculture, pharmaceuticals and automobiles. Rodríguez emphasised that Venezuela views India as a "preferred energy partner" due to the size of its economy and its long-term stability as a buyer. **p9**

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Rajesh Exports' 'gilded' accounts

JUGGLERY. SEBI exposes a multi-layered deception that went undetected by auditors, institutional investors

Nishanth Gopalakrishnan
Hari Viswanath
bl, research bureau

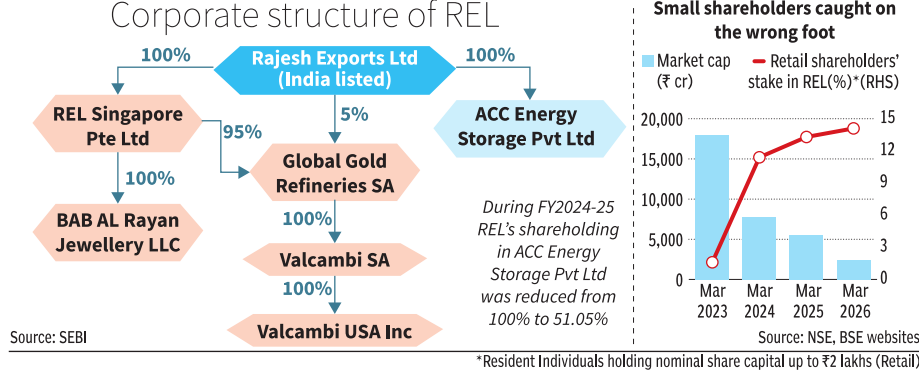
SEBI's searing report on the accounting irregularities indulged in by Rajesh Exports Ltd (REL) exposes a multi-layered deception that went undetected by auditors and institutional investors.

Aside from SEBI's incriminating findings (see table), quite a few numbers and metrics in REL's financial statements defy accounting logic. For example, capital turnover ratio of 2,698 per cent, a good 136 per cent higher than any company (non-financials) in the Nifty 500 and FY25 revenue of ₹4.2 lakh crore that would have ranked it in the top 10 amongst listed companies in terms of revenue while it had market cap of a small cap stock.

SEBI'S FINDINGS

The key among SEBI's findings is the questionable nature of ₹15.4 lakh crore worth of REL's revenue, spread over a five-year period from FY21 to FY25, while the actual revenue could roughly be a mere ₹3,000 crore.

REL is a gold refiner and manufacturer of gold products. Its corporate



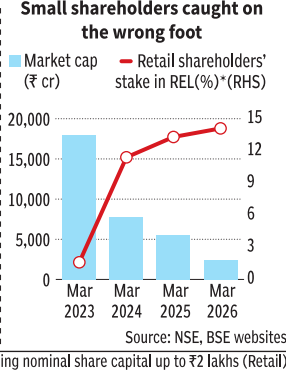
structure and consolidated revenue as reported are given in the chart and in the table respectively. REL's own standalone revenue, as in row 'B' (subject matter of another allegation) appears small against the consolidated revenue — implying that 97-99 per cent of the group's revenue is accounted for by the revenue of REL's subsidiaries.

While subsidiary Valcambi SA (Switzerland) is identified as the principal operating entity of the group, the rest of the entities are either just holding companies or ones with dormant operations. Hence, it is reasonable to assume that almost the entire group revenue is contributed by Valcambi SA (see row 'D' in table on Page 2).

Valcambi SA's standalone

books were audited under Swiss law by KPMG SA. While Valcambi SA accounted only for value addition in the refining process, its holding company accounted transactions on a gross basis — that is, recognise the value of gold received for refining as purchases and that of the refined gold as revenue — giving rise to the large revenue figures at the group level. This inconsistency in accounting treatment is what SEBI calls 'prima facie untenable'.

Given that Valcambi SA itself accounts only for the value addition, it is questionable how a non-operating holding company can recognise revenue differently — at the market value of goods belonging to third parties. SEBI argues that REL has not fur-



nished sufficient grounds such as bullion ownership records, inventory risk allocation or accounting opinions to justify the differential accounting treatment. GGR's consolidated books were prepared voluntarily and KPMG SA's opinion thereon does not constitute a statutory audit opinion under Swiss law. Further, it is not clear whether the accounts of main subsidiary REL-Singapore which accounts for almost entire revenue of REL were audited at all.

UNAUDITED ACCOUNTS

The FY25 annual report has a statement from Auditors BSD & Co that they had not audited the financials of any of the subsidiaries but had instead relied on a set of memorandum consolidated

financials of foreign subsidiaries that the board of REL itself had prepared for their unmodified opinion (clean report), implying that the subsidiary accounts were unaudited. Something like this gives ample space for gross misrepresentation.

Another important point in SEBI's findings is how the company claimed to have bought a mine in Africa for around ₹1,000 crore in FY23, but records reveal no identifiable investment. Further the cash flow statement in FY25 shows a 55 times increase in operating cash flows over FY24. Interestingly, almost entirety of it is from bizarre fall in trade receivables in a year in which revenue went by 51 per cent and trade payables rose sharply. Such big changes in trade receivables and trade payables adding to net cash inflows raises doubts on veracity.

Retail shareholders seem to have got sucked into all this drama. In the last three years as the shares crashed, retail shareholding increased from around 1.6 to over 14 per cent! And not to forget LIC, which still owns a sizable 10.8 per cent in REL (as of March 2025), marginally lower from around 11.04 per cent in March 2023.

Not one Re diverted, says Rajesh Mehta

Aishwarya Kumar
Venkatesha Babu
Bengaluru



Rajesh Mehta (file photo)

Rajesh Exports Chairman and Managing Director Rajesh Mehta has categorically denied allegations of funds diversion levelled by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), asserting that neither shareholder money nor company funds were used for the benefit of promoters.

"Not a single rupee of the funds of the company, neither shareholder funds nor company funds, has been diverted for any promoter's sake," Mehta told *businessline*.

SEBI'S CHARGE

His comments come after SEBI, in an interim order, alleged that Rajesh Exports *prima facie* misrepresented nearly ₹15.15 lakh crore in revenues linked to its subsidiaries and step-down subsidiaries between FY21 and FY25.

The regulator said the alleged misstatement accounted for 99.8 per cent of the revenues attributed to the company's overseas entities, creating what it described as an "inflated and misleading picture" of operations.

Responding to the allegations, Mehta said the observations related to investments by overseas step-down subsidiaries and not by the listed parent entity directly. "These are investments made by the step-down subsidiaries. These are foreign transactions and not investments made directly by the parent company. Everything is very clear, and all documents have been submitted," he said.

Mehta said the company had already furnished all information sought by the regulator. "We have not received any communication from SEBI for the last three months. Whatever observations have been made now... these are interim in nature, we will address them point by point, and I am quite confident SEBI (will understand our position)," he said.

Interview on **p2**

Services commanders' spend power doubled to fast-track procurement

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

In a major move to reduce bureaucratic delays and boost military readiness, the Army, Navy and Air Force commanders have been given more financial autonomy to fast-track defence revenue procurement of over ₹1.25 lakh crore annually.

The Ministry of Defence has radically streamlined its revenue procurement architecture. Under the revised Delegation of Financial Powers for the Defence Services (DFPDS) Rules, unveiled by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday, financial limits for the armed forces have been raised by up to 100 per cent, and even more in select cases.

The reform ensures that 80-90 per cent of contracts can now be cleared directly by the Services, bypassing the Ministry entirely. This is



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh during a meeting on the approval of enhanced financial powers for revenue-related procurement

the first update to the delegation framework since 2021.

The revenue procurement reform covers recurring expenses, inventory and services essential for the daily operations and sustenance of the armed forces.

This decentralisation of power does not extend to capital procurement, which covers acquisition of high-value, long-term strategic assets designed to build or upgrade core military capabilities.

FINANCIAL POWERS

In addition to the raised spending ceiling, there is an

overall delegation of special financial powers to the tri-Services commanders for urgent operational requirements, the Ministry said.

Sources privy to the development said that in the case of the Army, the financial powers of the Vice Chief had been increased from ₹500 crore annually to ₹750 crore for indigenous procurement, and from ₹275 crore to ₹500 crore for purchases from foreign vendors or government-to-government deals.

Likewise, powers of the Master-General Sustenance (MGS), headed by a Lt General-level officer, has gone up

from ₹350 crore to ₹500 crore annually for indigenous procurement, and from ₹125 crore to ₹225 crore for foreign purchases.

FINANCIAL AUTONOMY

The restructuring will lead to greater financial autonomy for Additional Directors-General in the MGS branch.

They can now take purchase decisions for indigenous projects up to ₹270 crore, up from ₹150 crore. In the case of foreign contracts, they can sign on orders worth ₹180 crore, up from ₹100 crore now.

Many new competent financial authorities have been introduced to decentralise the procurement of goods and services.

For instance, the Director-General Ordnance, for the first time, has been given financial powers to take decisions on projects up to ₹50 crore. Equivalent ranks in the Air Force and Navy will too get similar spend power.

India and US had positive discussions on trade deal, says Commerce Department

Our Bureau
New Delhi

India and the US held "constructive and positive discussions" on various issues, covering trade in goods and non-tariff measures, and "re-affirmed" their commitment to conclude a mutually beneficial bilateral trade agreement (BTA) that strengthens trade and economic ties, according to the Commerce Department.

A trade delegation from the US, led by chief negotiator Brendan Lynch, held negotiations with the Indian team from June 1-4, to advance negotiations on the BTA and push it towards conclusion. "The engage-

Both sides reaffirmed their commitment to concluding a mutually beneficial agreement that strengthens bilateral trade

ments were marked by a spirit of cooperation and pragmatism, with both sides reaffirming their commitment to concluding a mutually beneficial agreement that strengthens bilateral trade and economic ties," the statement issued on Thursday noted.

A possible timeline for

concluding the negotiations was not mentioned in the statement but efforts are on to have a pact in place as soon as possible, sources said.

INTERIM AGREEMENT

The Commerce Department release mentioned the India-US joint statement issued on February 7, 2026, agreeing on a framework for an interim agreement on reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade.

India had agreed to additional US tariffs of 18 per cent in the framework as at that time it faced US reciprocal tariffs of 25 per cent and another 25 per cent penal levy for buying Russian oil. Subsequently, the penal tariffs were rolled back by the Donald Trump regime

while the US Supreme Court invalidated the reciprocal tariff. It was replaced by a 90-day global tariff of 10 per cent that is set to lapse on July 24.

But India is now facing possible Section 301 tariffs of 12.5 per cent (for forced labour), with the tariff burden likely to increase after the second Section 301 investigation report (on excess capacity) is out.

"There is a possibility that the US will agree to cap the tariffs under the BTA at 18 per cent or so. That is what is being negotiated. India has demanded more market access than its competing countries such as Vietnam, Bangladesh and Indonesia," a source said.



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QUICKLY. ‘What’s in interim order is based on a misunderstanding’

PhysicsWallah to exit student finance biz

New Delhi: Edtech firm PhysicsWallah on Thursday said it plans to exit from the business of direct financing for students and instead partner with NBFCs for education loans. The move comes after a recent announcement wherein the company said it will invest ₹120 crore through an equity-infusion in its fully-owned subsidiary FinZ Finance Private Ltd. PTI

IHCL, Oneworld announce loyalty tie-up

Mumbai: Indian Hotels Company Ltd has partnered with global airline alliance Oneworld extending enhanced benefits to its loyalty club members. Through this collaboration, Taj InnerCircle-NeuPass members gain access to benefits on participating oneworld airlines, including limited time savings with Cathay Pacific until September 30. OUR BUREAU

REFUTES ALLEGATIONS. Have not received any communication from SEBI in the last 3 months; we will clarify every point before the regulator: Rajesh Mehta

bl.interview

Aishwarya Kumar Venkatesha Babu
Bengaluru

Facing scrutiny over alleged fund diversion and governance lapses flagged by market regulator SEBI, Rajesh Exports Executive Chairman Rajesh Mehta has rejected all allegations, maintaining that neither company nor shareholder funds were diverted. He defended the company’s overseas operations, receivables position and revenue reporting.

Edited excerpts:

SEBI has alleged that company funds were routed through promoter-linked accounts and used for derivative trading. I categorically deny that al-



We submitted over 400 GB of data and more than 60,000 pages of documents. Everything sought was provided

RAJESH MEHTA
Executive Chairman, Rajesh Exports



legation. Not a single rupee of company funds or shareholder funds has been diverted anywhere. There has never been any instance of diversion of funds for personal use. What has been stated in the interim order is based on a misunderstanding, and we will clarify every point before the regulator.

SEBI has also said complete records were not furnished during

the investigation, particularly relating to overseas subsidiaries. Absolutely not. We submitted over 400 GB of data and more than 60,000 pages of documents. Everything sought was provided. If there had been any shortfall, SEBI could have written to us. In fact, we have not received any communication from the regulator over the last three months seeking additional information.

FY-wise impact of misrepresentation (in ₹ cr)						
Particulars	2020-21	2021-22	2022-23	2023-24	2024-25	Total
Consolidated revenue of REL (A)	2,58,306	2,43,128	3,39,690	2,80,676	4,23,099	15,44,899
Standalone revenue of REL (B)	2,060	6,237	5,762	5,401	7,027	26,486
Revenue of subsidiaries/ Step-down subsidiaries (C=A-B)	2,56,245	2,36,891	3,33,928	2,75,276	4,16,072	15,18,413
Particulars	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	Total
Revenue of Valcambi SA (in ₹ cr) (D)	586	729	743	543	427	3,027
Misrepresentation (E=C-D)	2,55,659	2,36,163	3,33,185	2,74,733	4,15,646	15,15,385
% of misrepresentation (E)/(C)*100	99.77	99.69	99.78	99.80	99.90	99.80

Source: SEBI

We have fully cooperated and will continue to cooperate.

Have all transactions carried out been approved by the board, especially the related party transactions? Everything is above board. Whatever pointwise they have written, we are going to take up and respond.

The regulator has questioned investments

of over ₹1,000 crore in African gold-mining assets. What is your explanation?

These investments were made by step-down foreign subsidiaries and not directly by the parent company. They were overseas transactions undertaken by those entities.

All relevant records and supporting documents relating to those investments have already been submitted.

There is complete transparency regarding these transactions.

What would you like to tell investors, including institutions such as LIC and foreign investors, who may be concerned by the interim order? The promoters have not sold a single share of the company since inception (IPO), with promoters holding about 55 per cent. We do not have any idea of

selling the shares.

Have any funds of the company been diverted for personal use? Not a single rupee! The company funds have not been used for promoters. That is ruled out. I am very much in Bengaluru, and we are fully cooperating with authorities to bring out truth.

Eyebrows have also been raised about the management getting paid paltry sums in remuneration, including the CFO a mere ₹4 lakh per annum? I see no harm in it. There should have been concern if we overpaid ourselves, not the other way around. All I want to say is that an interim order is being blown way out of proportion. This (episode) has happened due to a communication gap.

Strong farm cash flows drive tractor demand; registrations rise 11.6 per cent in May

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Strong rural cash flows, replacement demand and dealer restocking pushed tractor registrations up 11.6 per cent year on year to 81,776 units in May, signalling continued resilience in the farm economy despite looming monsoon risks. Sequentially, registrations rose 6.4 per cent from 76,892 units in April, according to VAHAN data.

Analysts said the current cycle reflects improving rural liquidity and recovery toward the industry’s longer-term demand potential after two subdued monsoon years. M&M retained its dominant position with registrations of 34,275 units in May, up 9.8 per cent from 31,217 units a year earlier. It accounted for nearly 42 per



Tractors in the fast lane (units)			
OEM	May 2025	Apr 2026	May 2026
Mahindra & Mahindra (Tractor)	31,206	32,758	34,275
International Tractors	9,864	10,735	11,119
Escorts Kubota (Agri Machinery Group)	9,045	8,841	9,647
TAFE	7,504	8,543	10,659
John Deere India (Tractor Division)	6,740	6,166	5,954
Total	73,263	76,892	81,776

Source: Vahan Portal

cent of total registrations. International Tractors, which sells tractors under the Sonalika brand, recorded 11,119 units, up 12.7 per cent, continuing its steady growth momentum in rural markets. TAFE registrations surged 42 per cent to 10,659 units (7,504 units), helping the company overtake Escorts Kubota. Escorts Kubota reported comparatively moderate growth, with registrations

rising 6.7 per cent to 9,647 units.

DEMAND DRIVERS

John Deere registrations declined 11.7 per cent to 5,954 units despite the broader market’s double-digit growth. Analysts said the divergence suggests the current tractor cycle is being driven more by mass rural demand and replacement buying rather than premium mechanisation-led expansion, benefiting domestic in-

cumbents with deeper rural distribution networks and stronger financing reach. Industry observers said the current growth cycle is being supported by dealership inventory rebuilding, ahead of the festive and sowing season, too. Rating agencies have upgraded their full-year tractor industry growth projections to the 8-10 per cent range after two consecutive years of below-normal monsoons had capped demand recovery.

Brokerages also pointed out that tractors purchased during the industry’s strong 2018-21 volume phase are now entering the six-to-eight-year replacement window. “Momentum seems decent so far, but we’ll have to watch how the El Nino situation shapes up,” said Hemal Thakkar, Senior Practice Leader and Director at Crisil Intelligence. “Rural cash flows have been very strong, so the farm community remains healthy. Rain performance and fertilizer availability for the rabi crop will dictate tractor sales going forward,” he added. Analysts said the May data indicate India’s current tractor demand cycle is increasingly favouring domestic-focused manufacturers with strong rural distribution networks and exposure to value and mid-horsepower segments.

L&T inks investment MoU worth ₹18,600 cr with TN government

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Tamil Nadu government on Thursday signed an MoU with Larsen & Toubro (L&T) for three new major projects in the State that will bring investment worth ₹18,600 crore and generate employment for around 8,200 people.

This is the first major MoU that the newly-elected State government has signed since coming to power. The MoU was signed by KG Sathyanarayanan, Head - Initiatives, Development Cell, L&T Construction, and Alarmel Mangai, Executive Director, Guidance Tamil Nadu, in the presence of Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay and SN Subrahmanyam, CMD, L&T.

INFRA PUSH

The three projects are an Electronics manufacturing hub in Coimbatore at an in-



MILESTONE AGREEMENT. This is the first major MoU that the newly-elected Tamil Nadu government, under Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, has signed since coming to power

vestment of ₹2,500 crore; a Hyperscale & Edge AI Data Centre in Kancheepuram, establishing the next digital corridor beyond Chennai at ₹15,000 crore; and ₹1,100 crore towards the Kattupalli shipyard expansion, said a government release. L&T Chairman and Managing Director Subrahmanyam discussed the company’s ongoing and future investments in the State with the Chief Minister. According to the government release, the Chief Min-

ister also appreciated the company’s continued investments and strong industrial presence in Tamil Nadu. He also welcomed its proposal to establish three projects across different sectors in the State. These investments are aligned with the Chief Minister’s vision of transforming Tamil Nadu into a \$1.5 trillion economy by 2036, the release added.

The report was filed by intern Mahalakshmi Gururaj

Inox Clean to acquire Singapore-based Vena Energy’s 6-GW India RE portfolio for ₹6,000 crore

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Inox Clean Energy, the renewable energy platform of the INOXGFL Group, has signed a definitive agreement to acquire the 6 GW India renewable energy portfolio of Singapore-based Vena Energy in a deal valued at almost ₹6,000 crore. The portfolio comprises 1.2 GW of operational renewable energy assets, 1.8 GW of projects at an advanced stage of development and nearing commissioning and an additional 3 GW of development-stage projects spread across Gujarat, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh,

The Vena transaction is the Inox group’s 10th strategic acquisition in last 10 months

Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, a company spokesperson told *businessline*. The acquisition comes amid an aggressive dealmaking spree by Inox Clean Energy. In May, the company acquired the US solar manufacturing assets of Boviet Solar Technology LLC, part of China’s Boway Group, for about \$750 million, marking

one of its largest renewable energy transactions and a major expansion into the US market. The Vena transaction is the group’s tenth strategic acquisition in the last 10 months. **SCALE IPP PORTFOLIO** Devansh Jain, Executive Director, INOXGFL Group, said that the acquisition would further strengthen synergies within the group’s renewable energy businesses. “Inox Clean Energy continues to scale its IPP portfolio and targets annual capacity additions of more than 3 GW. A significant portion of its annual execution will be

executed by Inox Wind and would also translate into a massive increase in Inox Green’s portfolio,” he added. With the acquisition, Inox Clean’s operating and near-operational portfolio will expand to around 4 GW, while its total development pipeline will exceed 12 GW across solar, wind, hybrid and emerging clean energy opportunities. The assets come with long-term power purchase and offtake arrangements with customers including the Solar Energy Corporation of India, Gujarat Urja Vikas Nigam, State distribution companies, and commercial and industrial consumers.

Hyundai committed to make TN its flagship EV hub

Our Bureau
Chennai

Hyundai Motor India (HMI) on Thursday reaffirmed its partnership with the government of Tamil Nadu and said it is committed to making the State its “flagship EV Hub for India”. The company will roll out two models from the Sriperumbudur facility, including its first mass-market dedicated EV within this year, Tarun Garg, MD and CEO, HMI, said. The company is also focused on developing a future-ready skilled workforce, enabling talent to support future automotive technologies, said Garg. HMI has so far exported over 3.9 million



REAFFIRMING PLANS. Hyundai officials at a meeting with Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay

vehicles made in Tamil Nadu to more than 150 countries, he added.

LOCALISATION PUSH

HMI had already established Tamil Nadu’s first battery sub-assembly plant for EV powertrains and is actively localising power electronics and other key components, contributing to the

State’s ambition of becoming a leading EV manufacturing hub. HMI has established a DC fast EV charging ecosystem in Tamil Nadu with 39 stations and 78 charging points. Hyundai officials met Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Wednesday. HMI also committed to enhancing localisation

across both EV and ICE manufacturing operations and plans to increase localisation levels from the current 82 per cent to 90 per cent over the next five-six years. It aims to enhance purchasing value from State-based suppliers by about ₹4,000 crore, which is expected to create around 2,000 more jobs over the next five-six years. HMI also reaffirmed its continued investment of over ₹26,000 crore in Tamil Nadu over 2023-32, which was a part of the ₹45,000-crore investment announced earlier. The State government and HMI jointly announced a skill development collaboration to enhance the global employability of Tamil Nadu’s youth, which will kick off in December 2027.

Hindalco sees a big window of opportunity in Eternia

Have product portfolio for auto, AC, defence and building and construction sectors, says MD Satish Pai

Chitra Narayanan
New Delhi

Aluminium giant Hindalco Industries sees a big window of opportunity in its value-added downstream business that includes solutions for the auto, AC and building and construction industries. The company is targeting over ₹1,000 crore in revenue by FY29, from Eternia, its windows and doors brand alone, even as MD Satish Pai said the company was equally gung-ho about its fast growing auto and AC solutions. He said they would also be entering the modular kitchen space soon. Speaking at the launch of the first experience centre of Eternia in New Delhi’s



NEW BEGINNING. Kopal Agrawal, CEO, Aluminium Downstream, and Satish Pai, MD, Hindalco Industries, at the inauguration of the first experience centre of Eternia

Lajpat Nagar, Pai said, “We now have a portfolio of products that address the auto market like our battery enclosures in the EV segment, fins or the copper tubes that go into making ACs, high end products for defence sector and building and construction industry. Seeing the aspirational

growth that comes with the country’s growth is why we have gone into all these value-added products.” Of the 1.3 million tonnes of aluminium Hindalco produces, he said nearly half (about 600,000 tonnes) was now going into value-added products. Pai said in the downstream side of the

business, the company was getting a mark up of \$220 per tonne and in the next few years was targeting to touch a mark up of \$300 a tonne. In Eternia, which was born in 2020, the company has invested nearly ₹1,500 crore, he estimated, “if you consider the manufacturing capability, upgrades, retail and distribution and marketing”. Eternia products are manufactured and supported through key downstream facilities at Renukoot, Silvassa, Kuppam and Alupuram. In addition, a manufacturing hub was recently launched in Bilaspur in Gurugram. **FRAMING THE FUTURE** According to the company, the windows and façade

segment in India represents an estimated ₹40,000 crore market opportunity and is largely unorganised, with premium segments growing at nearly 15 per cent CAGR. Competitors in the segment include Fenesta, Schuco, and TOSTEM. Hindalco said Eternia, which uses a proprietary patented alloy called Duranium, was among the fastest-growing players in the system aluminium windows segment, recording nearly 65 per cent CAGR growth over the three years. According to Kopal Agrawal, CEO, Aluminium Downstream, Eternia operates through 170+ channel partners across 100+ cities and has 50 stores. “We plan to take it up to 100 stores by next year,” she said.

TVS SCS, Italy’s ALA Group partner to form aerospace and defence JV

Our Bureau
Chennai

TVS Supply Chain Solutions (TVS SCS) and Italy’s ALA Group have partnered to build an aerospace and defence supply chain platform in India. TVS SCS will have a 51 per cent stake, while the Italian firm will hold the rest; the JV will have an initial investment of ₹2 million, said R Dinesh, Executive Chairman, TVS SCS. TVS Packaging Solutions, a subsidiary of TVS SCS, will be revived and used to undertake projects for the JV, said sources. The proposed investment of around ₹10 crore in TVS Packaging aims to support business expansion initiatives and execution of definitive agreements with ALA Corporation for



Vittorio Genna, Vice-President and Co-Founder, ALA Group, and R Dinesh, Executive Chairman, TVS SCS BUJO GHOSH

collaboration and development of opportunities in India’s aerospace and defence sectors, says a stock exchange filing. The JV is targeting cumulative revenues of over ₹2,000 crore in three-five years, Dinesh said. The JV marks TVS SCS’ entry into the high-growth aerospace and defence sup-

businessline.

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QUICKLY.

ICICI Bank gets SEBI warning for FPI norm lapse



Mumbai: ICICI Bank said it has received a warning letter from SEBI for permitting a foreign portfolio investor to repatriate funds before the completion of the mandatory retention period under the voluntary retention route. In a disclosure to exchanges on Thursday, the bank said SEBI issued the warning letter on June 1, which was received by the lender on June 2. The regulator found that ICICI Bank, acting in its capacity as a custodian, had allowed one FPI to repatriate funds prematurely, resulting in a violation of the RBI's directions and SEBI's FPI regulations. The lender said the warning would have no material impact on its financial position, operations, or other business activities. **OUR BUREAU**

Motilal Oswal launches clean environment fund

Bengaluru: Motilal Oswal Mutual Fund has launched the new fund offer (NFO) for the Motilal Oswal BSE Clean Environment Index Fund, an open-ended fund replicating/tracking BSE Clean Environment Index. The NFO will open on Friday and closes June 19. The fund tracks the BSE Clean Environment Index, India's first diversified index purpose-built around the clean economy. It provides investors with a single, passive vehicle to participate in five transformative themes; Renewables, Electric Vehicles, Water Treatment, Recycling and Waste Management; all of which sit at the intersection of India's energy transition, environmental commitments and long-term economic growth. **OUR BUREAU**

SEBI to sharpen tech-led surveillance as online investment frauds rise

KEY PRIORITIES. Regulator to strengthen cybersecurity, conduct periodic audits, leverage surveillance tech

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India is working on technology-driven tools to combat online investment frauds and strengthen digital trust in capital markets, as the regulator increasingly shifts its focus towards prevention, surveillance and real-time detection of fraudulent activity. Speaking at a Ficci conference on next-generation fraud investigations on Thursday, G Ram Mohan Rao, Executive Director, SEBI, said the regulator had already rolled out investor-protection initiatives such as SEBI Check, App Check and UPI verification mechanisms, and is working on fur-

ther measures to curb frauds in the securities market.

"In fact, after introducing all those things, the frauds have reduced in this market. But it's still going on. We have got other tools for which we are trying to do," he said.

INVESTOR PROTECTION SEBI's approach is increasingly centred on identifying and stopping frauds before investors suffer losses, he said, adding that conventional investigations alone cannot keep pace with the scale of digital fraud.

"If you have got about a lakh fraudsters and a lakh investigations have to be done, how many people do I need? The system has to take care of it," Rao said. "The surveillance itself should do something."



RINGFENCING. G Ram Mohan Rao, ED, SEBI, said the regulator's approach is increasingly centred on identifying and stopping frauds before investors suffer losses

As part of that effort, SEBI has deployed surveillance systems that detect misleading investment-related content circulating on social media platforms. Once flagged, the content is analysed and referred to platforms for re-

moval. More than 1.4 lakh fraudulent posts have been taken down over the past one-and-a-half years through such efforts.

Around 53 per cent of the misleading content removed was from YouTube, with the

rest spread across Meta platforms, WhatsApp, Telegram and other channels, he said.

Deepfake videos are an emerging challenge for regulators and investors that can mislead even financially aware individuals given the increasingly sophisticated digital content.

He said strengthening cybersecurity systems, conducting periodic audits and leveraging advanced surveillance technologies would remain key priorities for investor protection. The executive director added that stronger data-protection practices and the implementation of the Digital Personal Data Protection framework would help build more robust systems and reduce vulnerabilities that fraudsters seek to exploit.

Nifty holds ground ahead of RBI decision; mid-caps shine

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The markets staged a recovery after a weak opening on Thursday, with benchmark indices closing nearly flat as investors stayed cautious ahead of the Reserve Bank of India's Monetary Policy Committee announcement due on Friday.

"Markets traded with a cautious tone on Thursday and ended largely unchanged on the weekly expiry day for the Sensex. The Nifty attempted a mild recovery but failed to surpass the previous session's high and eventually closed almost flat," said Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking.

The Sensex closed at 74,360.01, up 13.84 points, while the Nifty 50 settled at 23,416.55, gaining 10.95 points. The indices opened sharply lower — the Nifty gapped down 123 points at 23,282 — before buyers

stepped in near 23,250 and gradually erased losses through the session.

The broader markets continued to outperform front-line indices. The Nifty Mid-cap 100 rose 0.46 per cent to close at 60,966, and the Nifty Smallcap 100 ended in positive territory at 18,121. Market breadth was healthy, with 1,817 stocks advancing against 1,474 declining out of 3,396 traded. India VIX declined 2.41 per cent to 15.88, pointing to easing volatility.

SECTORAL TRENDS

Sectorally, Nifty Media led the gains, rising 2.19 per cent, followed by Consumer Durables at 2.18 per cent and Energy at 0.62 per cent. Metal, IT and Cement remained under pressure. Banking and pharma stocks ended the session with modest gains. Foreign institutional investors continued to be net sellers. According to provisional data, FPIs sold shares worth ₹4,447.06 crore.

GIFT City-based Marcellus Global Equities Fund to open on June 8

Our Bureau
Chennai

Marcellus Investment Managers Private Ltd-GIFT IPSC on Thursday launched Marcellus Global Equities Fund, a retail scheme designed to give Indian investors direct access to world-class global stocks. The new fund offer will open on June 8 and close on June 19.

The fund will invest in high-quality global compounds, targeting four multi-trillion-dollar structural megatrends — defence and aerospace, power generation, AI-linked capital expenditure and luxury con-

sumption, the Saurabh Mukherjee-led fund house said in a release.

Classified as a retail scheme under IFSCA regulations, the fund accepts a minimum investment of \$5,000 with a top-up facility of \$2,000. It carries a total expense ratio of 2 per cent per annum and an exit load of 2 per cent for redemptions made before 24 months, with no lock-in period.

TAX STRUCTURE NAV is declared on a daily basis. Taxes are paid at the fund level, eliminating the need for additional tax compliance at the investor's end, with long-term capital gains

taxed at 12.5 per cent after two years and short-term gains taxed at the fund's marginal rate before two years, the fund house said.

"The fund also offers the flexibility to redeem investments in foreign currency. Onboarding is entirely digital, requiring only PAN and Aadhaar details, with no need for investors to maintain a separate bank account in GIFT City," it further said.

Arindam Mandal, Head-Global Equities, Marcellus Group, said, "Our on-ground presence in the US gives us a distinct edge in identifying and investing in businesses that compound capital across economic cycles."

PGIM MF caps SIP in global funds

Our Bureau
Mumbai

PGIM India Mutual Fund has revised fresh systematic investment plan (SIP) registrations in three of its overseas-focused funds — PGIM India Global Equity Opportunities Fund of Fund, PGIM India Emerging Markets Equity FoF and PGIM India Global Select Real Estate Securities FoF.

Investments have been capped at ₹50,000 per day per investor from Friday.

Fresh systematic transfer plan into the schemes has been stopped from Thursday. However, existing SIP and STP will continue, the fund house said.

HDFC MF curbs gold ETFs, FoF flows

Fund house not to accept over ₹25 crore in gold ETF

Our Bureau
Mumbai

HDFC Asset Management Company, one of the largest mutual fund houses, has imposed temporary restrictions on large lump-sum investments in its gold exchange traded fund and gold ETF Fund of Funds (FoF) from June 5.

In an addendum issued on Thursday, HDFC AMC said in light of the broader economic and market conditions, it has been decided to temporarily restrict lump-sum subscriptions in HDFC Gold ETF and HDFC Gold ETF Fund of



Funds until further notice.

Subscription transactions by large investors making a minimum investment of ₹25 crore in Gold ETF directly with HDFC

Mutual Fund will not be accepted from June 8, it said.

Similarly, lump-sum purchases and switch-ins into HDFC Gold ETF Fund of Funds will be processed only up to ₹10 lakh per PAN per calendar month (at first-holder level).

INVESTMENT LIMITS

The limit will apply in respect of transactions received after the cut-off time of 3 pm on June 5, it said.

The move comes at a time when the government is urging consumers to avoid buying gold for a year to lower the import bill.

Hexagon Nutrition raises ₹41.7 crore from anchors

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Hexagon Nutrition has raised ₹41.66 crore from anchor investors ahead of its proposed initial public offering (IPO), allotting 92.58 lakh shares at ₹45 apiece.

According to details filed with the exchanges, the company allotted the shares to a clutch of institutional investors. Bandhan Small Cap Fund emerged as the largest investor in the anchor book, receiving 26.7 lakh shares, or 28.82 per cent of the anchor investor portion, translating into an investment of about ₹12 crore.

Other key participants included Ampersand Growth Opportunities Fund Scheme-I, which received shares worth around ₹10 crore, and CP Capital Ltd, which was allotted shares worth about ₹9.65 crore. Visionary Value Fund and Innovative Vision Fund were allotted shares worth nearly ₹5 crore each.

The company said no bids or applications were received from life insurance companies or pension funds in the anchor investor portion.

ANCHOR INTEREST

The anchor book witnessed participation from a diverse set of institutional investors. The company operates in the nutrition segment and has a presence across micronutrient premixes, therapeutic and clinical nutrition products, wellness offerings and fortified foods.

The IPO will open on June 5 and end on June at a price band of ₹42-45. The ₹138.87 crore IPO is entirely on OFS by existing (promoter) shareholders Arun Purushottam Kelkar, Subhash Purushottam Kelkar, Aditya Kelkar and Nutan Subhash Kelkar.

Hexagon Nutrition product profile included micronutrient premixes, therapeutic nutrition, clinical nutrition, wellness products and fortified foods.

Goldman Sachs acquires 0.18% stake in Groww from Frialé

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Global financial services firm Goldman Sachs on Thursday bought more than 1.13 crore shares of Billionbrains Garage Ventures, the parent company of Groww, from venture capital firm Frialé for ₹210 crore through an open market transaction.

Goldman Sachs, through its affiliate Goldman Sachs Bank Europe SE, purchased 1,13,43,750 shares, representing a 0.18 per cent stake in the Bengaluru-based trading platform, according to block deal data available on the BSE.

The shares were picked up at an average price of ₹185.50, taking the deal value to ₹210.43 crore.

Meanwhile, Frialé off-loaded the same number of shares, as per the data.

Shares of Groww rose 0.64 per cent to close at ₹190.05 apiece on the BSE.

BROKER'S CALL.

Geojit Equity Research

BALKRISHNA IND (BUY)

Target: ₹2,547
CMP: ₹2,192.20
Balkrishna Industries is a Mumbai-headquartered tyre company that manufactures and sells off highway tyres (OHT) to the earthmoving, mining, agriculture and gardening segments. In Q4FY26, its consolidated revenue rose 6.6 per cent year on year to ₹2,933 crore, aided by 5 per cent growth in sales volume to 85,820 mt. EBITDA grew 4.3 per cent to ₹640 crore in Q4FY26 because of the higher topline. However, EBITDA margin narrowed 50 bps to 21.8 per cent as raw material expenses (+11.6 per cent) and other expenses (+18.9 per cent) rose. Reported profit after tax (PAT) declined 18.7 per cent to ₹299 crore due to adverse movement in other income. The company's capital expenditure (capex) estimate for FY27 is ₹1,500-1,800 crore, along with an annual maintenance cost of about ₹200 crore. The company's performance in Q4FY26 reinforces confidence in the resilience of its core OHT franchise, with recovery visible in key overseas markets and continued strength in India, supporting a healthier volume outlook. While near-term earnings trajectory may be tempered by rising raw material prices, higher freight expenses and supply chain disruption linked to the geopolitical environment, these pressures appear manageable, with pricing actions expected to gradually offset the impact. Hence, we upgrade our rating on the stock to Buy, with a rolled-forward target price of ₹2,547, based on 26x FY28E adjusted EPS.

CD Research

MAHANAGAR GAS (BUY)

Target: ₹1,352
CMP: ₹1,074
According to Modern Intelligence report, India city gas distribution (CGD) is set to grow at a CAGR of 13 per cent during 2026-31. In order to capture the benefit of the growing CGD sector, Mahanagar Gas (MGL) added about 861 km to its aggregate steel and PE pipeline network (about 8,320 km) and 52 CNG stations (518 stations) in FY26. After investing over ₹1,060 crore in capital assets in FY26, MGL has drawn plans to further invest ₹1,000 crore for FY27. CNG prices increased this fiscal which will result in better realisation, going ahead. As a result of lower natural gas prices, operating profit margin fell from 21.6 per cent in FY25 to 17.6 per cent in FY26 and operating profits fell to ₹1,451.1 crore in FY26. We expect operating margin to falter further due to volatile gas cost due to US-Iran war and subsequently margins to fall from about 17.6 per cent this fiscal to about 16 per cent in FY27. Volatility in the pricing of natural gas matters more than physical sourcing as it is seller-agnostic, and the impact of war will harm them in increased costs and limited pass through rather than availability. With the goal of curtailing reliance on LPG, government efforts to push the adoption of PNG might help MGL to speed up new infrastructure roll-out and capture additional demand for piped gas. We assign 'buy' rating on the stock with target of ₹1,352, based on 15x FY27 earnings over 9-12 months.

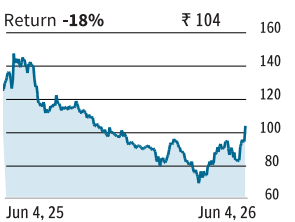
businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY'S PICK.

Zee Entertainment (₹104.38): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Zee Entertainment



The stock of Zee Entertainment Enterprises (ZEE) has been rallying since April. The ongoing rally began after the scrip found support at ₹68. On Thursday, it surged over 10 per cent, breaking out of a key resistance at ₹97.

This is also the neckline of an inverted head and shoulder and thus, the pattern now stands confirmed.

As per this chart set up, the stock has turned bullish and is likely to appreciate to ₹124 in the near-term. That said, there could be a price correction, probably to retest ₹97, before the next leg up.

So, traders can buy at ₹104 and accumulate at ₹97. Place stop-loss at ₹89. When the price touches ₹115 and ₹120, revise the stop-loss to ₹105 and ₹115 respectively. Book profits at ₹124.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23535» Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23350	23250	23550	23700	Buy the contract if it rallies above 23550; stop-loss at 23450.

₹754» HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
742	735	757	770	Go long if the stock rises above 757; place stop-loss at 742.

₹1200» Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1200	1176	1276	1300	Stock is trading near a support; buy with stop-loss at 1176.

₹280» ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
270	260	280	285	Stock faces a barrier; go short at 280 with stop-loss at 285.

₹267» ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
262	258	273	278	Buy the stock on a breakout of 270; keep a stop-loss at 262.

₹1304» Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1300	1250	1325	1340	Hovering near a strong base; go long with stop-loss at 1250.

₹979» SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
974	940	986	1000	Chart indicates positive bias; go long with stop-loss at 940.

₹2239» TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2220	2200	2260	2300	Go long if the stock surpasses 2260; keep a stop-loss at 2240.

Nifty 50 Movers					
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
ICICI Bank	1251.70	15.13	15.47	8.34	
Titan	4231.00	12.80	74.03	1.63	
Eternal Ltd.	254.35	11.55	670.65	1.71	
State Bank	979.25	7.97	10.43	3.79	
ITC	280.30	6.94	16.71	2.52	
Coal India	481.65	6.43	9.55	1.02	
Adani Enter	2972.80	2.95	38.60	0.79	
Cipla	1398.70	2.88	29.26	0.73	
Bharat Elec	409.90	2.58	49.43	1.37	
Bajaj Auto	10352.00	2.49	27.30	1.07	
Tech Mahindra	1487.30	2.08	30.32	0.68	
HDFC Bank	754.20	1.84	14.65	10.76	
M&M	3016.10	0.97	20.14	2.51	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	915.80	0.87	21.49	1.20	
Kotak Bank	381.50	0.80	19.67	2.62	
Tata Consumer Product	1149.30	0.75	73.53	0.70	
Tata Motors Pl	399.70	0.71	4906.48	0.78	
Maruti Suzuki	13664.00	0.57	27.98	1.60	
Dr Reddys Lab	1267.50	0.56	25.45	0.72	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	235.74	0.51	95.95	0.72	
Grasim Ind	3103.50	0.16	20.50	1.10	
Wipro	204.32	0.14	16.15	0.54	
Max Healthcare	966.00	0.13	55.19	1.07	
Trent Ltd.	2837.60	-0.06	87.90	0.88	
Asian Paints	2661.60	-0.08	58.09	1.12	
HDFC Life	573.75	-0.15	64.73	0.57	
Int'l Globevii	4508.80	-0.16	0.00	0.95	
TCS	2241.00	-0.16	16.40	2.13	
CNGC	267.55	-0.17	6.76	0.97	
NTPC	366.40	-0.41	12.90	1.62	
PowerGrid Corp	284.60	-0.44	16.62	1.20	
Eicher Motors	7110.00	-0.60	35.36	0.91	
Apollo Hosp	8249.00	-0.93	59.23	0.79	
Axis Bank	1253.30	-1.19	14.67	3.35	
NestleIndia	1382.90	-1.35	76.21	0.92	
Bajaj Finance	1874.00	-1.42	28.14	2.18	
SBI Life	1764.90	-1.89	71.66	0.74	
Sun Pharma	1780.10	-1.94	37.11	1.76	
Adani Ports	1790.90	-2.08	32.28	1.23	
Hind Unilever	2079.40	-2.17	46.17	1.72	
Tata Steel	210.57	-2.38	24.15	1.62	
SJSW Steel	1381.15	-2.41	12.47	1.14	
HCL Tech	1168.30	-2.46	19.04	1.15	
UltraTech Cement	10997.00	-2.69	39.58	1.21	
L&T	3942.10	-2.84	28.61	4.31	
Bajaj Finserv	1709.80	-3.10	13.91	0.92	
Bharti Airtel	1818.90	-3.48	32.77	5.20	
Hindalco	1125.60	-4.20	18.89	1.52	
Reliance Ind	1303.70	-14.00	18.42	8.21	
Infosys	1201.30	-16.29	16.53	3.92	

Pz's Impact on index movement					
Nifty Next 50 Movers					
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	937.90	60.52	123.43	2.59	
Cummins India	5787.50	33.63	67.93	3.15	
Rural Elec	355.20	33.27	5.41	1.69	
Power Finance	424.45	32.27	4.17	2.49	
Tvs Motor Cmp	3362.50	30.23	50.13	3.18	
Gail (India)	167.55	28.10	14.53	1.82	
Hyundai Motor India	1932.40	26.57	28.91	1.11	
Adani Energy Solutions	1520.00	26.34	76.31	2.13	
Cholamandalam&Fin	1486.00	18.62	24.19	2.57	
Bpel	295.15	17.45	4.95	2.41	
Indian OilCorp	138.95	16.56	4.49	2.09	
Indian Hotels Co.	661.55	15.01	41.90	2.34	
Bank Of India	271.35	12.83	6.99	1.73	
Canara Bank	133.12	12.09	6.75	1.81	
Godrej Consumer	995.40	10.11	54.72	1.61	
Britannia Ind	5090.00	8.65	48.33	2.42	
Hdfc AMC	252.92	7.42	37.82	2.07	
Divis Lab	6596.50	7.17	68.19	3.30	
YashoBiosciences	1084.60	5.65	23.50	1.09	
Linnindred	4057.70	3.93	24.40	1.52	
Siemens Energy India.	3700.90	3.57	100.62	1.32	
Tata Capital	311.20	2.56	27.01	0.54	
Macrotech Developers	881.75	2.03	25.67	1.00	
Indian Railway Finance Corp.	96.06	1.76	17.91	0.78	
Pidilint	1471.10	1.66	60.60	1.84	
Mazagon Dock	2445.20	0.73	35.79	0.75	
Uthmaniyah	167.44	0.87	6.87	0.35	
Ambuja Cements	426.35	-1.03	19.17	1.05	
Punjab Natl Bank	105.67	-1.27	6.58	0.47	
Tata Motors Cv	373.60	-2.06	45.43	3.15	
Vedanta	337.20	-3.36	8.08	2.24	
AdaniGreenenergy	1423.30	3.97	117.99	1.92	
Tadweer	410.80	-4.49	25.52	2.77	
Siemens	368.90	-5.66	85.66	3.31	
Aff Abba India	7156.00	-5.92	95.97	1.51	
Dif	577.80	-6.79	32.40	1.49	
Bajaj Holdings	10127.00	-7.70	115.17	1.77	
Hindus Zinc	603.85	-8.20	18.45	1.06	
Torrent Pharma	4339.90	-8.44	68.70	1.83	
United Spirits	2446.80	-10.95	55.52	2.77	
Oil India	1274.20	-11.01	48.69	4.49	
AvenueSuper	4139.30	-12.09	90.70	2.46	
Indust Jindal	3169.70	-14.71	12.00	3.37	
Jindal Steel	1197.20	-14.74	36.34	1.79	
Samarvad&othersInternat	144.31	-16.24	37.28	2.58	
Bosch	3070.00	-18.61	39.35	1.29	
Vardh Infra	508.80	-19.32	24.52	1.35	
San Industries	18293.00	-19.53	95.32	1.80	
Adani Power	230.03	-29.07	34.20	3.84	
HindustanAeronautics	4191.00	-39.15	30.75	3.21	



Chennai: Sundaram Home Finance said it plans to open another 25 new Emerging Business (EB) branches in South India this year. These will come up in tier-3 and tier-4 towns in Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Telangana, said the company, which crossed 100 EB branches last year. OUR BUREAU

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Y
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QUICKLY.

Fintech platform WeRize secures \$7 million funding

Bengaluru: WeRize, a Bengaluru- and Mumbai-based social distribution fintech platform designed for small-city India, has raised \$7 million in a pre-Series C funding round to fund its next phase of growth. The funding round was led by Sony Innovation Fund, with participation from existing investor 3one4 Capital. WeRize will use the fresh capital to deepen investments in its proprietary AI and technology stack, expand its product suite into investment products.

OUR BUREAU

Ola Electric raises ₹780 crore via QIP

New Delhi: Ola Electric Mobility has raised ₹780 crore through a qualified institutional placement (QIP) that was oversubscribed 56 per cent, driven by strong participation from domestic and global institutional investors, stock exchange data showed. The issue received bids worth about ₹780 crore, with demand from long-only investors, including global investment companies.

PTI

India, Venezuela seek deeper energy, economic partnership

BUILDING TIES. Discussions focus on oil, critical minerals and unpaid dividends

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Venezuelan acting-President Delcy Rodríguez and Prime Minister Narendra Modi held wide-ranging talks on Thursday focused on forging a stronger energy partnership while expanding ties beyond oil to several sectors such as critical minerals, mining, pharmaceuticals, agriculture, and automobiles.

Rodríguez emphasised that Venezuela views India as a “preferred energy partner” due to the size of the Indian economy and its long-term stability as a buyer, Rudrendra Tandon, Secretary (East) in the Ministry of External Affairs, said at a media briefing.

Modi said that India looked forward to building this relationship across both upstream and downstream activities. “Venezuela has already emerged as the third-largest crude oil supplier this month... There exists a per-



TRADE TALKS. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and acting President of Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela Delcy Rodríguez at Hyderabad House in New Delhi on Thursday ANI

fect complementarity for India and Venezuela to work in the energy sector,” Tandon said.

The five-day visit is both politically and economically important, taking place just five months after US forces detained former President Nicolás Maduro. Facing West Asia supply disruptions, India is actively diversifying crude sources, while Venezuela, which holds the world’s largest proven oil re-

serves, needs a reliable buyer. To explore collaborations, the Venezuelan delegation will visit several industrial sites, which may include Reliance Industries’ refinery in Jamnagar, Gujarat.

The Modi-Rodríguez discussions also went into broadening the overall bilateral economic partnership to other areas.

“Venezuela is a resource-rich country. It’s not just about critical minerals; it has

also gold, diamonds, and other materials. So, mining is very much there. In fact, there was a discussion on how to assess the potential reserves that they have, or whether we could cooperate in that area,” he said.

PENDING ISSUES
During the talks, India raised the issue of Venezuela owing over \$500 million in dividends to ONGC Videsh as well as payments owed to pharmaceutical companies. “All pending issues were raised... They (the Venezuela side) are very sensitive to the issue,” Tandon stated.

When asked if the recent political transition in Venezuela came up for discussion, Tandon highlighted the close relations shared with the country.

“We are working with a government that is friendly, that wants a partnership with India. We want to reciprocate that. Venezuela has traditionally been a very close friend,” he said.

ED closes FEMA probe against Myntra

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has closed its foreign exchange violation probe against Flipkart-owned e-commerce platform Myntra following a monetary settlement.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) issued a compounding order on April 20 to formally terminate the investigation into Myntra Designs Private Ltd, after receiving a ‘no objection’ clearance from the ED.

The central agency had initiated the probe last year following ‘credible information’ alleging two infractions under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA), involving transactions worth approximately ₹46 crore.

Rather than facing prosecution, Myntra opted for FEMA’s compounding provision, a regulatory mechanism that allows companies to settle offences by paying a monetary penalty.

The fashion-and-lifestyle retailer made a one-time payment of ₹2.88 lakh to close the case.

Consumers focus on savings, selective on spending amid global uncertainties: Report

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Amidst geopolitical volatility, Indian consumers are focusing on strengthening saving intentions and becoming more selective in spending on purchases that have long-term value but spends on travel and experiences remain high on their agenda. A survey released by Kantar stated that while consumer remain resilient in their outlook they are increasingly focused on financial security.

About 48 per cent of respondents surveyed said they expect the economy to improve in 2026, significantly down from 60 per cent in January.

Concerns around layoffs have increased from 36 per cent in January to 41 per cent in May.

Expectations around personal financial growth have also moderated. Sixty-one per cent of the respondents expect their savings and investments to either remain same or decline versus 2025, only 39 per cent expect them to increase, the survey findings revealed.

Deepender Rana, Executive Managing Director, South Asia, Kantar, said: “Our latest report shows that Indian consumers remain resilient but are becoming noticeably more cautious as economic and geopolitical uncertainty rises. Confidence in future financial growth has softened, while concerns around job security, retirement preparedness and rising living costs have intensified. As a result, consumers are becoming more deliberate in how they spend, prioritising savings, value and long-term financial security, while continuing to protect experiences that enhance their wellbeing and

quality of life. For brands, this presents a clear imperative: demonstrate tangible.”

MORE CAUTIOUS

The findings suggest consumers are becoming more cautious about both the broader economic environment and their own financial prospect. Future financial preparedness is emerging as one of the strongest concerns for Indian households with healthcare expenses continuing to be the biggest financial worry.

Nearly two-thirds of respondents said they are “very likely” to save more for their own and their family’s future.

“However, financial pressures remain evident, with 33 per cent reporting a decline in savings and investments compared with 2025, while only 28 per cent report growth,” it added.

However, rather than cutting consumption altogether, consumers are becoming more deliberate about where and how they spend, the survey said. Spending intentions across discretionary categories such as dining out, entertainment, shopping and subscriptions have weakened but spending intentions on travel and experience remain resilient.

“At the same time, consumers continue to favour assets perceived as offering long-term value and security. More than half (52 per cent) say they are very likely to purchase gold over the next 12 months,” it added.

India-UK minerals observatory unveiled

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The India-UK critical minerals Global Supply Chain Observatory (GSCO) was formally launched on Thursday by Coal & Mines Minister G Kishan Reddy and Yvette Cooper, UK’s Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs.

The launch marks a milestone in the growing India-UK partnership on critical minerals and supply chain resilience, reinforcing co-

operation in securing the resources essential for clean energy, advanced manufacturing and electric mobility.

CRUCIAL BACKBONE

Addressing the gathering, Reddy emphasised that critical minerals are the backbone of modern economies and indispensable for clean energy technologies, advanced manufacturing, electric mobility and strategic sectors.

He noted that the Observatory would strengthen India’s capabilities in critical mineral supply chain intelli-

gence, support evidence-based policymaking, and advance the objectives of the National Critical Mineral Mission.

Cooper underscored the importance of India-UK collaboration in developing resilient, diversified and sustainable critical mineral supply chains.

She stated that greater access to critical minerals and improved information-sharing are in the mutual interest of both nations and can contribute significantly to economic growth and supply chain security.

Zepto eyes \$1 billion order mark in June

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Quick commerce platform Zepto is likely to cross the \$1 billion-mark in terms of net order value (NOV) by the end of June quarter as it eyes a public listing. This comes at a time when the company has been focusing sharply on profitability and financial discipline strategy.

Sources said that the quick commerce platform’s net order value is expected to grow to over \$1 billion in June quarter from about \$500 mil-

lion in late 2025 and has been scaling up despite growing competitive intensity in the sector. Zepto has been focusing on reducing cash burn per order while focusing sharper focus on stronger unit economics and profitability, they added. The platform had reported a cash burn per order of about ₹200 in the early half of 2025.

INITIAL APPROVAL

Last month, Zepto received initial approval from markets regulator SEBI for its confidential initial public offering and is reportedly in

the process of filing an updated draft prospectus.

In October last year, the pure play quick commerce platform had raised about \$450 million in a funding round led by California Public Employees’ Retirement System and General Catalyst, valuing it at about \$ 7 billion. Other existing investors, including Avenir, Avra, Lightspeed and Glade Brook had also participated in the round.

The platform seems to have a strategy of focusing on serving 61 cities with a higher focus on metros.

Government of Kerala
Published Tenders from 01-06-2026 to 03-06-2026

Stationery Department

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Tender ID: 2026_STY_853720_1 * Stationery Controller * Supply of White Offset Paper 75 gsm RA1 * Closing Date: 20-Jun-2026 * PAC: Rs3300000

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Ro.No:01-03/Jun/2026/PRD/(N)/7

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3	1500020994	Procurement of Structural materials
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5	2000094940	03 year contract for AMC ROAD CLEAN & WATER SPRINKLING
6	2000093678	2 Yrs OLA for Servicing of Boiler HP valves and safety valves

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Email: roynr@isgec.com, Website: www.isgec.com

NOTICE
SPECIAL WINDOW FOR RE-LODGE MENT OF TRANSFER REQUESTS OF PHYSICAL SHARES:

This is to inform all concerned shareholders that pursuant to the SEBI Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)/2026-MIRSD-POD/1/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, a special window for the re-lodgement of transfer deeds relating to physical shares has been opened for a period of one year from February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027. This Special Window is available for physical shares sold or purchased prior to April 01, 2019, including cases where:

- Transfer requests were earlier submitted and rejected/returned/not attended to due to deficiencies in documents or processes; or
- Such transfer requests are being lodged afresh, subject to fulfilment of prescribed conditions.

Please note that the shares so transferred under this Special Window shall be mandatorily credited to the transferee only in demat mode and shall be under lock-in for a period of one (1) year from the date of registration of transfer. Such securities shall not be transferred/lien-marked/pledged during the said lock-in period. Concerned shareholders are advised to take note of this opportunity and re-lodge their transfer requests along with the requisite documents to the Company’s Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (‘RTA’), **Alankit Assignments Limited**, Alankit House, 4E/2, Jhandewalan Extn, New Delhi-110055, Tel: 011-42541234, 23541234; Email: rta@alankit.com or rmap@alankit.com.

100 DAYS CAMPAIGN- “SAKSHAM NIVESHAK”: Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority (‘IEPFA’) has initiated the second 100 days campaign- “Saksham Niveshak” from April 01, 2026 to July 09, 2026 to reach out to shareholders whose dividend(s) has remained unpaid / unclaimed and whose Know Your Customers (KYC) and other details have not been updated.

During this Campaign, the Shareholders having Unpaid Dividend / Unclaimed Dividends or whose KYC & Nomination details have not been updated are requested to reach out the Company’s RTA at the address given above. An e-mail in this regard can be sent to the Company at roynr@isgec.com.

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The shareholders are also requested to claim their unclaimed dividend amounts, otherwise the same will be transferred to Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF) after expiry of seven years along with the shares, wherever required.

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Compliance Officer
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J&K Bank wins Finacle award for AI platform

Srinagar: J&K Bank has won a Gold award at the Finacle Innovation Awards 2026 for its Data Insights and Analytics Platform. It was presented in the category “Modern Technologies-led Innovation – Data Insights & Analytics Platform” at an event organised by Infosys Finacle in Mumbai. MD and CEO Amitava Chatterjee received the award along with GM (Strategy and IT/CIO) Mohammad Muzaffar Wani. **OUR BUREAU**

GVRP, StepsBio set up R&D CoE Bengaluru

Hyderabad: GV Research Platform of Hyderabad and Bengaluru-based Steps Biosciences have jointly set up a Center of Excellence for formulations R&D, GSRC, in Bengaluru. It is a dedicated facility for formulations R&D. GSRC represents GVRP's expansion into high-complexity formulations, an area increasingly central to the global drug development pipeline, a release said. **OUR BUREAU**

Japan’s robotics start-up Jinki-Ittai seeks Indian partners to make humanoid robots

M Soundariya Preetha
Coimbatore

Japan-based robotics start-up Jinki-Ittai is looking for partners in India to manufacture its human-operated robots.

Kanaoka, President of Jinki-Ittai (Man-Machine Synergy Effectors, Inc), who inaugurated the 21st edition of the industrial machinery exhibition INTEC 2026 organised by the Coimbatore District Small Industries Association in Coimbatore on Thursday, told *The Hindu* that it has patents for all its technologies.

“We have partners in Japan who make robots for the Japanese market. We are looking for similar partners in India too,” he added.

Jinki-Ittai robots are used in Japan for the maintenance of railway lines and so on. “These robots are targeted for application in areas where human lives are at risk,” he said. The start-up is specifically exploring opportunities in India in foundries and railways.

The start-up, valued about ₹179 crore (¥3 billion), hopes to promote the use of its robots on a subscription basis. “We are ex-

PM to unveil ₹22,655 cr projects across Gujarat, Daman & Lakshadweep today

GROWTH PUSH. Projects to span roads, power, healthcare, aviation and industrial infrastructure sectors

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

A new terminal building at Namo Airport in Daman and stretches of the Vadodara-Mumbai Expressway will be among the projects worth ₹22,655 crore which Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate, dedicate or lay the foundation stone for across Gujarat, Daman and Lakshadweep on Friday.

According to an official statement, the Prime Minister will launch projects worth around ₹18,800 crore in Surat, ₹2,970 crore in Daman and ₹885 crore in Lakshadweep spanning roads, power transmission, industrial infrastructure, healthcare, civil aviation, tourism and maritime connectivity.

The Prime Minister will begin his visit in Gujarat's Surat district, where he is scheduled to visit Hazira and review the ongoing industrial operations and infra-

structure projects there.

ROAD CONNECTIVITY

Among the key projects in Gujarat, Modi will dedicate to the nation Packages VI and VII of the 8-lane access-controlled Vadodara-Mumbai Expressway.

The expressway sections are expected to improve high-speed transportation and logistics efficiency between Gujarat and Maharashtra.

He will also lay the foundation stone for the four-laning of critical sections of National Highway-56, improving connectivity across tribal regions while enhancing access to the Statue of Unity.

In the healthcare sector, the Prime Minister will inaugurate a 200-bed Employees' State Insurance Corporation (ESIC) hospital in Surat.

Other projects to be inaugurated in Gujarat include power transmission network



DEVELOPMENT PUSH. Prime Minister Narendra Modi will visit Surat district and then travel to Daman to launch projects

expansion works under the Inter-State Transmission System, power distribution upgrades in Valsad under the Revamped Reforms-Based Distribution Sector Scheme, advanced effluent disposal and treatment infrastructure at the Dahej Petroleum, Chemicals and Petrochemical Investment Region and the Sarigam Gujarat Industrial Development Corporation, as well as layout utilities at the Jambusar Bulk Drug Park.

Later in the day, the Prime Minister will travel to Daman, where he will inaugurate the new terminal building of Namo Airport and dedicate the Namo Hospital to the nation.

Namo Hospital, the district hospital in Daman, has been developed to cater to nearly 1,500 outpatients daily and is expected to improve access to healthcare services in the region.

Projects worth around ₹1,340 crore will be inaugur-

ated and dedicated in Daman.

Modi will lay the foundation stones for projects including the Iconic Bridge, Daman Convention Centre and a National Institute of Fashion Technology campus totalling over ₹1,630 crore.

IN LAKSHADWEEP

The Prime Minister will also lay the foundation stone for four projects worth around ₹885 crore in Lakshadweep.

These include the development of port facilities on the eastern and western sides of Kalpeni and Kadmat islands.

The projects involve construction of multi-purpose jetties that will facilitate year-round berthing of large passenger vessels, including cruise ships.

The facilities will support passenger and cargo handling while also providing integrated infra for fish handling, fuel distribution, ice supply and boat repair.

Truck rentals remain steady amid fuel price hikes: Shriram Mobility bulletin

Our Bureau
Chennai

India's mobility and logistics sector witnessed a turbulent yet structurally resilient May 2026.

Truck rentals remained wobbly during the month, weighed down by multiple price increases coupled with demand slackness, which prevented fleet operators from passing on the full impact of rising fuel prices, according to the Shriram Mobility Bulletin.

MARGINAL UPTICK

Truck rental rates across major trunk routes remained broadly stable to marginally positive on a month-on-month basis, with the Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru route recording a 2.1 per cent month-on-month uptick.

Most other routes held steady or unchanged.

“Chakka Jam disruptions in NCR and repeated fuel price hikes created significant strain, but weak demand limited the ability to pass on costs fully. While OEMs welcome the government's support for replacing older BS-IV vehicles with cleaner alternatives in Delhi-NCR, fleet operators remain uncertain about

the continued usage of BS-IV trucks that still meet pollution norms post November 1,” said Sudarshan Holla, Joint Managing Director and Chief Operating Officer-Commercial Vehicles, Shriram Finance.

EV SURGE

Electric vehicle (EV) sales continued to accelerate with cars leading the charge with a 157 per cent year-on-year

growth in retail sales during May 2026. Electric three-wheelers climbed 87 per cent y-o-y, while electric two-wheelers surged 78 per cent y-o-y. The traditional automotive sector maintained a broadly positive trajectory on a y-o-y basis. Retail sales of goods carriers rose 10 per cent, passenger motor cars 24 per cent, three-wheeler goods carriers 25 per cent and two-wheelers 7 per cent.

Parliamentary Panel flags slow private investment and FDI outflow

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

A Parliamentary panel on Thursday raised concerns about the flow of private investment and the flight of Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) from India.

These issues were discussed during the meeting of the Standing Committee on Finance under the Chairmanship of Bhartruhari Mahtab. The meeting was called for a briefing by Economic Affairs Secretary (Anuradha Thakur) and Chief Economic Adviser (V Anantha Nageswaran) on ‘General Economic Situation in the Country’. Nageswaran made a detailed presentation on the current scenario.

Talking to the media after the meeting, Mahtab said that despite the headwinds, India's economy is also evolving in a better way, with certain very good indicators. Household savings have increased in comparison to last year, and investment is also increasing. “The challenge is when government investment is increasing, capital investment is growing, and private investment is not picking up in the same vein. That is a challenge we have to address,” he said.

He said that while India has been able to attract FDI, there is also a flight of FDI from the country. According to him, the Chief Economic Advisor characterised it as “cyclic” in nature. “In three years when investment increases, foreign direct investment increases, but in

another three years there is also a flight,” he said, quoting the CEA.

FDI CHALLENGE

The gross inward FDI inflows rose to \$94.5 billion in 2025-26, up from \$80.6 billion a year ago. However, net FDI stood at \$7.6 billion, though nearly 700 per cent higher than in 2024-25.

“The greater challenge is that the US is attracting foreign direct investment in large numbers. Another challenge is that after 2022, the interest index of most of the countries is increasing. Japan had zero interest in their savings; now they are providing 2-3 per cent interest on certain bonds. So the flight of money is happening towards these developed countries, whereas earlier, the emerging economies were getting this investment,” Mahtab said, adding that these are certain challenges which India has to go through, but India has a very good market.

CHINA FACTOR

A significant part of the discussion focused on China's policy environment and the opportunities for India to attract companies seeking to diversify their manufacturing bases away from China. Mahtab said: “That is a concern. And for that, certain policy changes are required. At the same time, those who are moving out of China — what type of support will we be providing them in our country to set up their industry? That is also something.”

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IndiGo suspends flights to six Asian destinations



Mumbai: IndiGo is temporarily suspending flights to six destinations in South-East Asia and China due to high operating costs and soft demand, said the airline. As part of its cost optimisation measures, the airline is cutting flights to Hong Kong, Ho Chi Minh City, Krabi, Langkawi, Shanghai and Siem Reap. The suspension will remain in effect between July and September. IndiGo will resume bookings for all the impacted services starting from October 1, it said on Thursday. The flight cuts come in the backdrop of weak fourth quarter results, which saw the airline slipping into the red. IndiGo posted a loss of ₹2,536 crore in Q4 FY26, weighed by rupee depreciation and low yields. **OUR BUREAU**

SC panel proposes regulations against AI-assisted sentencing

MAN VERSUS MACHINE. Concerns grow over use of AI in rendering judgments without human intervention

Aaratrika Bhaumik
New Delhi



HEIGHTENED SAFEGUARDS. The draft regulations permit the use of AI for administrative functions, but make it clear that it cannot be used for “risk scoring” in court processes

Prohibiting the use of artificial intelligence (AI) to determine judicial outcomes, the Supreme Court AI committee has proposed draft regulations that bar AI-assisted sentencing without mandatory human oversight, prevent AI systems from profiling parties or witnesses and disallow the use of “opaque” or “unexplainable” AI systems in any court process.

The proposed regulations come amid concerns expressed by the top court in recent months over the growing reliance on AI by courts in rendering judgments.

In March, a Bench headed by Justice PS Narasimha chided a trial court for rely-

ing on non-existent judgments generated with the help of AI, observing that it was not merely “an error in decision-making”, but amounted to judicial “misconduct”.

The preliminary draft of the ‘Regulations for Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in Courts, 2026’, made public on Wednesday, underlines that AI systems used in court

processes must “function solely in an assistive capacity”, and remain “strictly subservient to human judgment and judicial authority”.

The committee, chaired by Supreme Court judge PS Narasimha and comprising Justices Sanjeev Sachdeva, Raja Vijayaraghavan V, Anoop Chitkara and Suraj Govindaraj, has invited comments and suggestions from

stakeholders as well as members of the public on the draft regulations before they are finalised. The deadline for submitting the responses is June 20.

‘DIGITAL DIVIDES’ Under the draft regulations, the processing of personal data through AI systems shall be governed by the provisions of the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023.

It also underlines that AI systems must not “perpetuate, amplify, or introduce bias” on grounds of race, religion, caste, sex, gender, disability, language, economic status, or any other ground prohibited under the Constitution.

“Applications involving higher levels of risk to personal liberty, any lawful right of a person, or the integrity of judicial outcomes shall be

subject to correspondingly heightened safeguards, including mandatory human-in-the-loop requirements and independent oversight,” the draft states.

It further cautioned that AI-assisted judicial systems should not “widen digital divides” and must remain accessible to all stakeholders.

While the draft regulations permit the use of AI for administrative functions such as case management, preparation of cause lists, scheduling of hearings, transcription of court proceedings and translation of judgments, they make it clear that AI systems cannot be used for “risk scoring” in court processes.

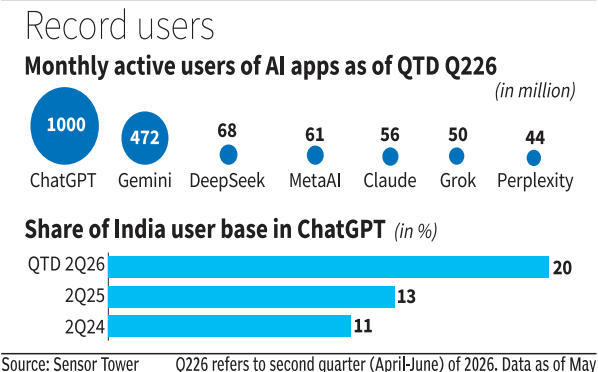
This includes assessing flight risk, predicting recidivism, evaluating bail eligibility, or determining the credibility of parties or witnesses.

ChatGPT crosses 1 billion active users in 3 years of launch

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

OpenAI’s ChatGPT has become the fastest app to ever reach 1 billion global monthly active users (MAUs) as of May 2026, and India makes up 20 per cent of this cohort, data from market intelligence firm Sensor Tower has showed. More than 200 million of these ChatGPT MAUs are from India.

The share of Indian user base is up to 20 per cent currently from 13 per cent in the second quarter of 2025 and 11 per cent in Q2 2024,



showcasing increasing adoption of the ChatGPT app by smartphone users in India, Abe Yousef, Senior Insights Analyst, Sensor Tower, told

businessline. ChatGPT has achieved this significant scale at a time when the app is taking Claude head on in its race to

capture more users. As of May 2026 (QTD Q2 2026), Sensor Tower pegs Claude global MAUs at 56 million.

Thanks to OpenAI’s head-start, ChatGPT is thus far ahead of Gemini (472 million), DeepSeek (68 million), Meta AI (61 million), Grok (50 million), Perplexity (44 million) and Copilot (31 million).

ChatGPT has, in many ways, become synonymous to Generative AI, being the first such tool experienced by customers which has helped OpenAI achieve this milestone in roughly three years.

“Comparatively, it took

Google Maps, Google Chrome, Messenger, TikTok, YouTube and Instagram each between 5-8 years to cross 1 billion global app MAUs,” said Yousef.

However, ChatGPT has not been the fastest. Meta AI (973 per cent) and Claude (640 per cent) are leading ChatGPT’s growth rate of 62 per cent in year-over-year MAU growth through QTD Q2 2026.

“Claude’s growth could be driven by significant model advancements (and enhanced capabilities) in the past year or rising consumer sentiment after the announcement of OpenAI’s

partnership with the Department of War in Q1 2026,” said Yousef.

RACE TO THE TOP

Further, heightened competition and advancements in other AI models have weighed on ChatGPT user engagement.

Data indicate that ChatGPT users who installed Claude in the first quarter of 2026 spent 5 per cent less time on ChatGPT one month after the installation of Claude. Advancements in Claude’s model capabilities and brand positioning over the past year could be driving this trend, Yousef noted.

Snap moves beyond social media views, bets its marketing on ‘attention currency’

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

As Gen Z consumers reshape content consumption and shopping habits, advertisers are moving beyond impressions and clicks towards deeper engagement metrics, says the Snap India MD.

The era of measuring digital advertising success through reach, impressions and video views is coming to an end, according to Snap India Managing Director Pulkit Trivedi, who believes “attention” will emerge as the most valuable currency for marketers targeting young consumers. As Gen Z users increasingly discover products through private conversations, communities and creator content rather than traditional social feeds, brands will need to rethink how they advertise, Trivedi told *businessline.*



“The next big currency in measurement or advertising is going to be attention,” said Trivedi.

“Nobody wants to see an ad. What brands need to know is whether consumers actually paid attention to their message and whether that attention is translated into outcomes.”

Trivedi estimates India’s digital advertising market,

currently valued at over \$10 billion, could expand to \$18-20 billion over the next three to five years.

Snap is positioning itself at the centre of this transition by focusing on immersive advertising formats that combine augmented reality, video and messaging experiences. Trivedi argued that traditional linear marketing funnels are breaking down as content discovery, commerce and social interactions increasingly overlap.

“The classic funnel is not linear anymore,” he said. “Discovery, shopping and conversations are all happening simultaneously, and brands need to adapt to that reality.”

YOUNG CUSTOMERS

The strategy appears to be resonating with advertisers. Snapchat’s advertiser base in India has grown tenfold over the past two years, according

to the company. “We’ve moved from being an experimental platform to becoming a core part of media plans for many advertisers,” said Trivedi.

MOMENTS MARKETING

Snap is also investing heavily in AI-powered advertising tools, including automated bidding, audience targeting and creative optimisation.

The company is also doubling down on what it calls “moments marketing”, targeting cultural events such as IPL, Diwali and Holi when user engagement surges.

During the recent IPL season, Snap deployed a real-time advertising format that triggered brand offers when a six was hit during a match.

“The emotional affinity associated with how a brand message shows up during these moments is very different, and we’ve seen it translate into outcomes,” he said.

Tamara Leisure launches hotel brand for pilgrimage hubs

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Tamara Leisure Experiences (TLE) has forayed into the religious tourism segment with a hotel brand designed to meet the needs of pilgrims.

Hotels under the Rae by Tamara brand will provide the faith conscious dining options like Satvik meals and meditation rooms for guests, among other things.

The hotel and resorts chain, backed by the families of Infosys Co-founders SD Shibulal and Kris Gopalakrishnan, has nine properties in operation and eight under development.

In the first phase, existing properties in Guruvayur and Kumbakonam, consisting of 40-45 keys, will be rebranded and opened in July and August. An 80-key hotel is being developed at Velankanni in Tamil Nadu at an investment of ₹70 crore and will open in 15 months. “The Rae by



DIVINE DESTINATION. Religious destinations have over 13,100 branded hotel rooms, comprising 6 per cent of the total room inventory in India

Tamara brand has been designed around the behaviours and needs of pilgrims rather than traditional hotel operating manuals,” said TLE Chief Executive Officer Samir MC.

“For example, in many pilgrimage destinations, the most important ritual of the day may begin at 4 in the morning. That means guests are waking up at 3 or 3.30 am, getting ready and heading to

the shrine. Most hotels are simply not designed for that reality. In our hotels we want to ensure that guests have access to hot water, support services and food at the time they actually need them,” he said.

Like wildlife naturalists, the properties will also have individuals well versed with history, architecture and traditions of the shrine.

According to consultancy

HVS Anarock, religious destinations in India have over 13,100 branded hotel rooms comprising 6 per cent of the total room inventory in the country. The largest market by number of rooms are Amritsar, Katra, Tirupati, Varanasi and Dwarka.

Another 19,760-plus rooms are in construction, accounting for 14 per cent of the pipeline, HVS Anarock said. In terms of pipeline, the largest markets are Ayodhya, Amritsar, Pushkar, Tirupati and Varanasi.

HOSPITALITY MODEL

“We are positioning RAE by Tamara as India’s first faith-intelligent hospitality brand. We do anticipate having around 25 properties signed or operational by 2030,” said Samir.

The company is looking at both ownership and asset light models for development, he said. In FY25, TLE posted revenue of ₹150 crore and a net loss of ₹16.4 crore.

Komatsu and SMFG India Credit Co. Ltd. Launch Finance Scheme to Empower First-Time Machine Buyers and Small Fleet Owners

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New scheme offers attractive interest rates, financing of up to 90% of machine cost and a 4-5 year repayment period to make Komatsu machine ownership more accessible.



Komatsu India Private Limited (KIPL) and SMFG India Credit Co. Ltd. (SMICC) have announced the launch of a dedicated finance scheme designed to support a wide range of customers, including first-time buyers, small fleet owners and entrepreneurs, in purchasing Komatsu Hydraulic Excavators.

The scheme has been curated to address one of the biggest challenges faced by small business owners and first-generation entrepreneurs: access to finance. The scheme aims to bridge this gap by making machine ownership more accessible and affordable to a broader customer base. Alongside, SMFG aims to leverage this partnership to expand financing solutions to fleet operators as well, a key and established segment in the market.

Under this scheme, eligible customers can receive financing of up to 90% of the machine cost at an attractive rate of interest. The scheme has been structured with a repayment period of 4-5 years, giving buyers a practical and manageable route to machine ownership. With attractive interest rates, high funding support and a longer repayment window, the scheme helps customers plan their EMIs better, generate income from their equipment and build their business with greater confidence.

Large-scale activity across roads, highways, railways, metro rail, industrial corridors, logistics, irrigation, mining and urban infrastructure is expected to create significant opportunities for contractors and equipment owners across the country.

Against this backdrop, the finance scheme combines attractive financing with the proven performance of Komatsu Hydraulic Excavators. Designed for rugged Indian operating conditions, Komatsu machines are known for their Quality, Reliability and Durability. Backed by dependable service support from Construction & Mining Machinery Business (CMMB) of Larsen & Toubro, Komatsu’s exclusive distributor in India, the initiative is designed to help entrepreneurs participate more actively in India’s infrastructure growth story while operating with greater confidence, productivity and long-term business potential.

The scheme is available for a range of Komatsu Hydraulic Excavators, including Komatsu PC81, PC136, PC205, PC210 and PC225. These machines cater to a wide range of applications across construction, infrastructure, excavation and earthmoving projects.

Speaking on the launch, **Mr Nobukazu Takeuchi,**

Managing Director, Komatsu India Private Ltd, said, “At Komatsu, we believe that our customers’ success is our success. This finance scheme is an important initiative that enables more customers to access Komatsu’s high-quality construction equipment and unlock new opportunities for business growth. Through our partnership with SMFG India Credit, we aim to lower the barriers to machine ownership and contribute to the sustainable growth of India’s construction and infrastructure sectors.”

Mr. Ravi Narayanan, MD & CEO, SMFG India Credit said, “We are delighted to partner with Komatsu India to offer seamless and accessible financing solutions to their customers across the country. As a trusted equipment financing partner, our endeavour is to empower first-time buyers, small fleet owners and entrepreneurs with structured credit solutions that make machine ownership more affordable. At SMFG India Credit, we remain committed to empowering aspirations through accessible financial solutions that enable progress, create opportunities and foster inclusive growth across communities.”

The finance scheme is currently available in South India, North-West India and select parts of East India. Customers can approach their nearest dealerships or authorised representatives to check eligibility, available models, documentation requirements, and the detailed terms of the scheme.

By making finance more accessible for first-time buyers, Komatsu and SMFG India Credit aim to encourage entrepreneurship, support small and mid-sized contractors, and contribute to the growth of India’s construction and infrastructure sectors.

For sales and finance-related queries, please contact us at cmb@larsentoubro.com or call 1800 833 9990 / 1800 266 9990.

About Komatsu

Komatsu is a leading global manufacturer of construction, mining and utility equipment, known for advanced technology, reliability and high-performance machines.

About SMFG India Credit

SMFG India Credit Co. Ltd., a leading NBFC - Investment and Credit Company (NBFC-ICC) registered with the Reserve Bank of India and a wholly owned subsidiary of Sumitomo Mitsui Financial Group (SMFG), has been operating in India since 2007. Together with its subsidiary, SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. also known as SMFG Grihashakti, the company has established a pan-India presence, across 670+ towns and 70,000+ villages through 1000+ branches and 22,500+ employees offering lending products to underserved & unserved retail and small business borrowers. By doing so, it has introduced people to formal credit. SMFG India Credit along with SMFG Grihashakti offers a comprehensive range of lending solutions, including SME financing, commercial vehicle and two-wheeler loans, home loans, home improvement loans, loans against property and shares, personal loans, and rural livelihood advancement loans etc.

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IKEA sets up product development company

Our Bureau
New Delhi

In a bid to strengthen its presence, Inter IKEA Group on Thursday said it has set up a new entity, IKEA Product Development Centre India. The company will support the development of affordable and well-designed home furnishing products for customers in the country as well as globally.

“India has been an important sourcing market for IKEA for more than 40 years. To further increase local sourcing and develop unique, well-designed home furnishing products in India for both local and global customers, Inter IKEA Group has established a local company, IKEA Product Development Centre India, that will support the development of products on behalf of IKEA of Sweden,” it added.

UNIQUE CAPABILITIES

It added that the local company will support product development through the re-

The company will support the development of affordable and well-designed home furnishing products

gion’s unique capabilities and competencies, connected to the supplier base in India. “Our goal is to develop a relevant and affordable range for the many people in India and around the world, while building on the country’s unique capabilities — from rich craftsmanship traditions and local raw materials to a wide range of production setups, spanning highly automated factories and artisan-based production,” said Oskar Lindkvist, Managing Director, IKEA Product Development Centre India.

“All products are developed in line with the IKEA Democratic Design principles, balancing form, function, sustainability, quality and always starting with affordability,” he added.

